

Appendix I — Online Safety Act 2023

Compliance Opinion

Subject of opinion: DEQUAD (DEQUAD Ltd in formation), operated at <https://dequad.co.uk>

Author of internal assessment: Yusuf Quadri (Founder) **External counsel of record:** [Law firm to be appointed — recommended panel: Bristows, Mishcon, Wiggins, Schillings] **Date of latest review:** _____

I.1 Purpose

This document is an internal compliance opinion summarising DEQUAD's position under the **Online Safety Act 2023** ("OSA") and is intended to demonstrate to UK Endorsement Services Ltd that the applicant has identified the obligations applicable to the business and has built the product with them in mind.

A signed external legal opinion from a UK-qualified solicitor in good standing will be commissioned during Month 2 post-endorsement and attached to this appendix at the next UKES contact point.

I.2 Categorisation of DEQUAD under the OSA

Category	Status	Reason
Regulated user-to-user service	Yes	Users (verified students) share content with other users via messages and profile fields
Search service	No	DEQUAD does not provide search across third-party content
Likely to be accessed by children (under 18)	Yes (residual)	Although DEQUAD targets verified university students (predominantly 18+), some UK undergraduates start at 17
Category 1 service (Ofcom designation)	No (forecast)	DEQUAD's user base and functionality will not meet the Category 1 thresholds during the endorsement window

Practical implication: DEQUAD is a **Category 2B-equivalent** user-to-user service with residual exposure to under-18 users. The applicable duties are summarised in §I.3.

I.3 Applicable duties

Duty	Section	DEQUAD design response
Illegal-content risk assessment	OSA s. 9, s. 10	Completed; reviewed annually. See §I.4 below
Illegal-content safety duties	OSA s. 10	Real-time keyword scanning + escalation to DSL; reporting flow built; takedown SLA defined
Children's risk assessment	OSA s. 11, s. 12	Completed under assumption of residual under-18 access. See §I.5
Children's safety duties	OSA s. 12	High-risk safety setting default-on for all users; no algorithmic recommendation of strangers to flagged-under-18 accounts
Content-reporting and complaints procedures	OSA s. 17	"Report a profile" feature live since 2026; complaints SLA 4 hours human triage
User empowerment (Cat 1 only)	OSA s. 14	Not applicable (Cat 2B)
Freedom of expression / privacy	OSA s. 22	DPIA documents necessity + proportionality of every safeguarding scan
Record-keeping	OSA s. 23	All safeguarding events logged for 7 years; risk-assessment versions retained
Designated content moderator	OSA s. 56	DSL appointed; backup DSL named
Ofcom information requests	OSA s. 100	Process in place: 7-day response SLA

I.4 Illegal-content risk assessment summary

Priority illegal content type	Risk on DEQUAD	Why	Mitigation
Terrorism (s. 59)	Very low	Closed UK university network; no anonymous posting; no public discoverability	Standard keyword scan + reporting flow
Child sexual abuse (CSAM)	Low	Verified .ac.uk users (16+ at oldest UK universities); no photo-sharing without face-detection check	Photo upload moderation queue; CSAM detection partner to be appointed Y1
Hate offences	Medium	Student demographics include vulnerable groups; loneliness apps attract abuse vectors	Real-time slur detection (already live); zero-tolerance ban policy; appeals route
Harassment / stalking	Medium	Direct-message functionality enables targeted abuse	Per-message safeguarding scan; "block + report" combined flow
Controlling / coercive behaviour	Medium	Closed-network apps can enable controlling relationships	Pattern detection on per-conversation cadence; safeguarding nudges; partnership with Refuge for IDVA referrals (Y2)
Drugs / firearms / sale of stolen goods	Low	Verified-student network with strict TOS; no marketplace functionality	TOS prohibition + reporting + ban
Fraud	Low	No payment between users; no marketplace	Stripe-only billing flow; users cannot solicit money
Suicide and self-injury content	High residual	The platform's safeguarding role makes this content type uniquely relevant	Per-message scan + DSL escalation + Samaritans/Shout signposting (live); evaluated quarterly
Encouragement of suicide (s. 184 OSA)	High residual	As above	Active scanning; "encouragement" patterns distinct from "expression of distress" — DSL judges
Animal cruelty / extreme pornography	Very low	No mass-media upload; profile photos only	Profile-photo moderation queue

The full Illegal Content Risk Assessment (ICRA) is kept on file and reviewed annually. Methodology aligns with Ofcom's **Online Safety: Illegal Harms Guidance** (December 2024).

I.5 Children's risk assessment summary

DEQUAD is designed for verified UK university students. The platform's verification gate (active `.ac.uk` email) excludes the vast majority of under-18 users. However:

- A small number of UK undergraduate students begin their first year aged 17 (typically birthday-rule edge cases).
- Some Foundation-Year and Access course students at partner FE institutions may be 16+.

The Children's Risk Assessment therefore treats DEQUAD as a service with **residual exposure to under-18 users** and applies the corresponding precautions:

Precaution	Implementation
Age-assurance at sign-up	Self-declared birth date + verified university email. Stronger age-verification under evaluation for Year 2
Default privacy-protective settings for likely under-18 accounts	No discoverability via search; no exposure to adult users >5 years older without dual opt-in
Children's content-design code (ICO AADC) alignment	Designed in from launch: data minimisation, no profiling, no dark patterns
Education and reporting tools tailored for younger users	Plain-English help; one-tap "I need help" route to Childline (for under-18 self-identified users)

I.6 Designated roles and accountabilities

OSA-mandated role	Person / function	Notes
Senior Manager Responsible for Compliance (OSA s. 56)	Yusuf Quadri, CEO (with Yusuff Adeagbo, CTO, as deputy)	Joint founder accountability documented in board minutes
Designated Safeguarding Lead	<i>Yusuf Quadri, CEO, personally (a qualified safeguarding professional) through Y1–Y2; a dedicated part-time Safeguarding & Trust Lead is planned for Y3, contingent on 2+ paying universities and funded entirely by revenue — see Business Plan §18.3</i>	Job description in Appendix G
Data Protection Officer	<i>Outsourced fractional throughout Y1–Y2 (e.g. The DPO Centre, low-cost pay-as-you-go); an in-house FTE DPO is not assumed in this 3-year plan and would only be considered later if data-processing scale justifies it</i>	
Ofcom liaison point	Yusuf Quadri, CEO (Y1); transition to in-house counsel Y3	

I.7 Engagement with the regulator (Ofcom)

Activity	Status
Registered for Ofcom's small-platform information service	Pending Month 1 post-endorsement
Subscribed to Ofcom guidance updates	✓ Live
Familiarity with Ofcom's Guidance for Smaller Providers (2025)	✓ Reviewed
Plan for Ofcom transparency reports (if Cat 1 designation triggered)	Documented; no current Cat 1 forecast within endorsement window

I.8 External legal opinion — scope of work to be commissioned

The external legal opinion to be commissioned in Month 2 post-endorsement will cover:

1. Confirmation of DEQUAD's categorisation under the OSA;
2. Sufficiency of the Illegal Content and Children's Risk Assessments;
3. Sufficiency of the content-reporting and complaints procedures;
4. Adequacy of record-keeping;
5. Risk register for foreseeable Ofcom enforcement;
6. Boilerplate Terms of Service and Acceptable Use Policy review;
7. Confirmation that the founder's senior-manager-responsible accountability is appropriately recorded.

Estimated cost: **£8,000–£12,000** (firm fee dependent). This exceeds the £4,500 NatWest in-kind legal allocation (Business Plan §10.3) and is not separately budgeted in the Y1 cash P&L (Appendix F, where Y1 legal & accountancy is £300, out-of-programme only). The founders will either scope a narrower opinion within the NatWest in-kind panel's capacity, or fund the shortfall from founder cash reserves or defer to Y2 once revenue supports it — this is not yet a fully funded commitment.

I.9 Statement

The applicant has read the Online Safety Act 2023 in full, has read the Ofcom illegal-content and children's-safety guidance, and has designed DEQUAD's product, processes, and policies to comply with the duties applicable to a Category 2B-equivalent user-to-user service. The applicant will obtain external legal confirmation of this position within the first six months of operation and will produce that opinion at the 6-month UKES contact point.

Signed: _____ Yusuf Quadri

Date: _____